

Athenian philosophy



In the fifth century BCE, Athens emerged as the major *polis*, or city-state, of mainland Greece. Already a significant military and trading power in the region, social and political reforms initiated by the statesman Solon led to Athens adopting a form of democracy in 508 BCE. The ensuing prosperity and security allowed a flourishing of culture in the city – especially in the arts of music, theatre and poetry – and attracted intellectuals from other parts of the Greek world. Among them were Anaxagoras, from Ionia, and Protagoras, from Abdera in Thrace, who introduced the idea of philosophy to the city.

Athens was ideally suited to fostering philosophy and quickly became the centre of Greek philosophy, producing some of the most influential thinkers of all time. But more than that, Athenian cultural and political life influenced a change in the direction of philosophy, shifting emphasis from metaphysical concerns to the more humanist questions of moral and political philosophy.